THE TORTUOUS TRAJECTORY OF PAKISTANI ELECTIONS

Pakistan's first national general election, in 1970, led to the creation of Bangladesh. In the 10 subsequent elections to the National Assembly, only twice has a single party won a majority. Moreover, not one prime minister has ever completed a full five-year term

1947-1970

Post independence, Pakistan held provincial polls in Punjab and NWFP in 1951, Sindh in '53 and E. Pakistan in '54. A constitution under which a nationwide poll could be held was implemented in '56, but there was political turmoil, with a succession of PMs appointed and dismissed. In '58, martial law was imposed and Gen. Mohd Ayub Khan staged a coup, postponing the polls slated for '59. The election held under his watch in '62 was indirect, with no political parties involved



1977

Out of 200 elected National Assembly (NA) seats, the Pakistan Peoples Party, led by **Zulfikar Ali Bhutto**, won 155—a landslide victory. The Pakistan National Alliance (PNA), a coalition of right-wing parties, won only 36 seats. However, there were allegations of rigging against the PPP, and mass demonstrations

★ Army chief Gen. Zia-ul-Haq declared martial law amidst the unrest, and Bhutto was arrested. Gen. Zia seized power in a coup in July 1977. Later, murder charges were brought against Bhutto and, after a long trial and appeal process, he was hanged on April 4, 1979

1985

Elections were held under the military government of **Gen. Zia** on a non-partisan basis, without the participation of political parties. Independents who were supporters of Zia won all 207 electable seats in the NA. Movement for Restoration of Democracy, a group of parties opposing Zia, boycotted the polls



★ A government was formed, with Muhammad Khan Junejo as PM. In March 1988, Zia dismissed it for being "corrupt and inefficient" and called another party-less election, but his death in a plane crash in August meant Pakistan could return to multi-party polls



1988

PPP, led by Bhutto's daughter **Benazir**, won 93 out of 204 seats in the NA; followed by 56 won by the Islami Jamhoori Ittehad (IJI), an alliance of pro-Zia parties led by Pakistan Muslim League leader Nawaz Sharif

★ PPP formed a coalition government; Benazir Bhutto became the first female PM of a Muslim nation

★ President Ghulam Ishaq Khan dismissed Benazir's government in Aug. 1990 for 'corruption', 'misgovernance'



1990

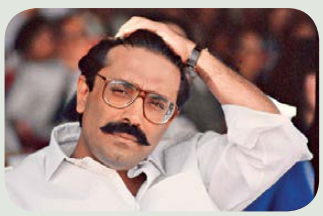
The **Nawaz Sharif**-led IJI alliance won 105 out of 207 NA seats, beating the four-party People's Democratic Alliance (PDA) led by the PPP and Benazir, which won only 44. Sharif was sworn in as premier, though the opposition accused him of corrupt electoral practices

★ Sharif tried to curb the powers of President Khan, who dismissed his govt for 'corruption' in 1993. Sharif won a court appeal, but resigned, as did Khan

1993

The PPP won a majority of seats—89—in the NA, but it was not enough. Sharif and his newly named party, Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz), won 73 seats. Like in '88, Benazir formed a coalition with the aid of smaller parties and became PM for a second time

★ Amid charges of corruption against the PM and her husband **Asif Ali Zardari** and political turmoil, President Farooq Leghari dismissed the government in '96



1997

PML-N won 135 general seats out of 217, making it a landslide mandate against corruption. PPP could win only 18 seats. Sharif became PM for a second time; Benazir left the country in a self-imposed exile

★ After the Kargil War in 1999, Sharif attempted to remove army chief **Gen. Pervez Musharraf**, who ousted him in a coup in 1999 and took over as president in 2001

★ Sharif was arrested and tried for corruption and was handed a 14-year jail sentence. He went into exile. Gen. Musharraf called for elections in 2002

